

Marry Me?! - Part Three

By midday, the rain had settled into a steady, persistent drizzle that softened the entire landscape into muted greys and greens. It muffled sound, blurred distant outlines, and drove most honest travelers indoors, leaving the roads and lakeshore unusually empty. Heka, crouched atop a rocky outcrop overlooking the water, brushed wet strands of hair behind her ear as she studied the shoreline with sharp, focused eyes.

"There," she said quietly, her voice barely rising above the rain.

Hidden among the reeds sat an old boathouse. Its weathered wood and sagging roof suggested abandonment at first glance, but none of the three were fooled. Weiyun narrowed her eyes slightly as she observed it, her tone calm but certain when she spoke.

"It isn't abandoned," she murmured.

Baoyu, standing just behind her, gave a small nod of agreement. "Fresh footprints. Multiple sets."

Weiyun continued the analysis without hesitation. "Three different sizes, and the mud near the entrance has been disturbed recently."

Heka tilted her head, grinning faintly as she added, "And someone dragged something heavy inside not long ago. A cart, maybe."

For a brief moment, the three exchanged glances, and in that shared silence there was complete understanding. Their suspicions had been correct from the beginning.

The boathouse itself contained nothing of interest at first glance—just rotting nets, broken oars, and the stale scent of old wood. But beneath a stack of decaying crates, Baoyu

discovered a concealed trapdoor reinforced with iron bands. He knelt, examined it carefully, and lifted it with controlled effort.

A rush of cold, stale air rose from below.

"Tunnels," Baoyu said simply, hand gesturing at the now exposed ladder entrance.

Heka's grin widened immediately. "My favorite kind of suspicious architecture."

Without hesitation, the three descended one after another into the darkness below. The air grew colder as they went deeper, and the sound of the rain from the surface faded into near silence. What they found was far more extensive than any of them had expected.

The tunnels beneath the lake stretched in a sprawling network of stone corridors, some ancient, others recently reinforced. Old escape routes branched into forgotten passageways, while newer supports of fresh timber and iron brackets revealed that someone had been actively restoring and using the system. Lantern hooks lined the walls at regular intervals, and the ground bore unmistakable traces of regular traffic.

Weiyun's voice was low as she observed their surroundings. "It appears that more than a few people are up to no good here."

Baoyu nodded, eyeing the tracks and noting how fresh some of them were. "And recently."

They followed the tracks deeper until faint voices began to echo ahead.

Smugglers.

The cavern they entered opened into a wide underground chamber where half a dozen men were busy loading lacquered chests onto carts. Others unpacked stolen goods—silk bolts, jade ornaments, medicinal herbs, and sealed bottles of expensive wine. The operation was efficient, practiced, and bore all signs of being well-established.

At the center of the chamber stood something far more elaborate: a mechanism composed of cogs, pulleys, levers, and ropes. Wood and metal built together into something quite intricate. Suspended from the pulleys was a life-sized figure dressed in red robes that seem to have never seen a dry moment in their existence. Long black...hair? obscured what might have been a face. A system of gears and weighted counterbalances connected to a concealed shaft.



Baoyu's eyes narrowed slightly. "When activated..."

"...it rises through the water's surface," Weiyun finished quietly.

Heka nodded, clearly impressed despite herself. "And the lantern inside makes it glow. From a distance, it would look like a drowned bride emerging from the lake."

One of the smugglers turned a crank, and the mechanism slowly engaged. The figure began to rise with eerie smoothness, water dripping from its sleeves as it ascended through the hidden shaft.

Heka let out a silent whistle. "I'll admit... that's actually impressive."

At that exact moment, one of the smugglers glanced toward the tunnel entrance. His expression froze seeing the three heroes who made no attempt to hide their arrival. "...Boss?"

Heka lifted a hand in a casual wave. "Hey," she said brightly. "You all," she waved her pointed finger in their direction, "have been caught."

The fight that followed was, in every sense, one-sided.

The smugglers outnumbered them significantly, but numbers meant very little when faced with three martial artists who moved with seamless coordination. Baoyu flowed through the battlefield like water, every strike precise and efficient, his robes barely disturbed by the chaos around him. Weiyun fought with disciplined control, each movement economical, each opponent disabled with careful restraint rather than unnecessary force.



Heka, in typical Heka fashion, was pure chaos.

She laughed as she fought, vaulting over crates, swinging from beams, and using whatever was within reach in the environment to her advantage. At one point she disarmed a man using his own cargo net, which she later insisted was "absolutely intentional strategy."

"I planned that!" she called out cheerfully.

Baoyu deflected another attack without looking at her. "You absolutely did not."

"I believed in myself," Heka replied.

"That is not the same as planning." Baoyu knew exactly how to tease her.

"Flexibility still counts!" Heka pouted.

Within minutes, the cavern fell silent. The smugglers lay scattered across the floor in various states of defeat, groaning and thoroughly defeated.

Weiyun exhaled slowly. "I almost feel bad." Her foot lightly tapped one of the smugglers, just to make sure he was still breathing.

"They'll recover," Heka said brightly. "All kinds of justice waiting for them, after all. Would be a shame for them to get the easy way out."

After securing the smugglers for local authorities to finish dealing with, and ensuring the stolen goods were properly documented, the three returned to the tunnel system to search for anything they might have missed. Most of the side passages led to collapsed storage rooms, old wells, or dead ends long since sealed by time.

Then Heka stopped abruptly.

"...Wait."

She knelt beside a section of wall that looked no different from the rest, tapping the stone lightly with her knuckles in a very exaggerated show. The sound echoed faintly. Baoyu handed her a torch without a word.

Heka tested several stones in sequence.

Thunk.

Thunk.

Thunk.

Then a hollow echo. You might think it was just bad construction, but here in the depths of tunnels and ancient architecture...it was certainly out of place. Her grin widened instantly and she gestured enthusiastically for Weiyun. "Don't you just love hidden doors?"

Weiyun approached slowly, wondering what exactly Heka was up to. She inspected the area briefly and quickly discovered a nearly invisible pressure mechanism embedded in the stone. She slowly applied pressure until the mechanism reacted. With a low grinding sound, the wall shifted inward and slowly slid aside.

Beyond it lay a chamber untouched for centuries.

Dust coated every surface. The air smelled ancient, still, and undisturbed. Several heavy wooden chests lined the walls, their surfaces intact and unbroken by time.

The trio entered the room, Weiyun leading the way. Her eyes wide in astonishment. It was clear to both Heka and Baoyu that the wheels in her head were spinning a mile a minute.



Wei opened the nearest chest carefully.

Gold. Not a handful of coins, but an overwhelming quantity in all shapes and configurations...coins, ingots, rings, chains, hair pins....

She quickly withdrew her hand and gasped softly into her hand. An act Heka found incredibly adorable which only made her feel all the more pleased with herself. She motioned for Wei to open the next chest.

Silver ingots.

Another... More jewelry, jade carvings, sealed scroll cases, ceremonial weapons—each chest revealed a different form of wealth, all preserved perfectly.

Even Weiyun found herself momentarily speechless. She turned to the other two to see if they were as stunned as she and only found Heka watching her. Not a glance spared towards the treasure, just Heka watching Weiyun with an affectionate gaze

“...This has nothing to do with the smugglers.”

Baoyu nodded slowly from where he leaned at the doorway, “The dust hasn’t been disturbed. They were pretty efficient in only carrying out their own schemes and didn’t have the guts to inspect beyond the tunnels they needed.”

Weiyun examined the structure of the chamber. “This also predates the tunnel renovations. It’s been sealed for a very long time.”

Heka, meanwhile, looked between them with an expression that was far too pleased with herself. Then she stepped closer and gestured dramatically toward the chamber. “Wei.”

Weiyun blinked. “What?”

Heka spread her arms wide. “Surprise.”

A pause.

“...this?”

Heka smiled. “I remembered your face when Baoyu mentioned abandoned tunnels.”

Weiyun walked further into the chamber cautiously, her fingers brushing over an ancient bronze vessel as if confirming it was real. Then, unexpectedly, she laughed—softly, genuinely, without restraint.

When she turned back, Heka was watching her with a smile that somehow felt brighter than the treasure itself.

"Why go out of your way...?," Weiyun said quietly.

"I wanted to," Heka replied simply.

"You wanted to?"

Heka tilted her head. "Your eyes twinkled when you mentioned it that one time. Then during our recon before you joined us...an opportunity presented itself."

Weiyun paused.

"...That's your reason?"

Heka nodded. "You ask as if that's a bad reason."

For a moment, Weiyun said nothing. Then she crossed the chamber, stopping just in front of Heka. Without overthinking it—without hesitation for once—she rose slightly onto her toes and pressed a quick kiss to Heka's cheek.

Then she immediately stepped back.

"...Thank you," Weiyun said, her voice suddenly much quieter.

Silence fell.

Heka stood completely still.

"..."

"..."

"...Baoyu," Heka said slowly, her voice barely above a whisper as Weiyun busied herself with *inspecting* the treasure (which really was super interesting and worthy of her inspection).

"Stay calm," Baoyu replied.

Heka touched her cheek as if verifying reality. "...She — "

"It appears so," Baoyu said calmly, placing his hand reassuringly on her shoulder in an attempt to ground her.

Weiyun suddenly found the floor far more interesting than the jade carving she had found. "It was... just a gesture of gratitude."

Heka's expression broke into a radiant smile. "A gesture I will treasure forever."

Weiyun covered her face. "I regret everything."

"No, you don't," Baoyu said, laughing.

No, Weiyun admitted only to herself. *I don't.*



They spent the next hour cataloguing the chamber's contents. The wealth inside was staggering—enough to fund entire regions, or support generations of charitable work, or simply remain untouched as a forgotten relic of history.

Eventually, Heka stretched and looked between them. "So... what now?"

Weiyun studied both of them carefully. Heka's boundless energy. Baoyu's quiet steadiness. The ease with which they had come to trust one another.

Then she smiled.

"If you'll have me," she said slowly, "I think I'd like to stay."

Heka immediately lunged forward and hugged her. "We'd love that!"

Baoyu smiled warmly as he leaned casually against a surface he had dusted clean for himself. "I suspected as much."

Weiyun blinked. "Was I that obvious?"

"You've smiled more in two days than I think you have in years," Baoyu replied.

"...Fair," she admitted.

That evening, after the smugglers were carted off to the local magistrate, the three returned to the inn where this leg of their journey had begun. The atmosphere was lighter now, filled with laughter, shared food, and the easy rhythm of companionship.

Eventually, Heka pointed at Baoyu. "Your turn."

Baoyu raised an eyebrow. "My turn?"

"We've both shared our stories," Heka said. "I already know yours but Weiyun wants to know too!"

Weiyun nodded. "She's right. Your turn."

Baoyu sighed theatrically, though there was no real reluctance in his expression. "Very well." He leaned back slightly, swirling the wine in his cup as he began.

"I was born the eldest son of a silk merchant family. I was expected to inherit everything—business, responsibility, reputation. But I never wanted any of it."

Heka nodded knowingly, having heard nearly all of Baoyu's stories.

"Let me guess. You wanted to be a wandering hero," Weiyun guessed.

Baoyu smiled. "Exactly."

He explained how his father had hired some of the most brutal martial arts instructors in hopes of correcting his "foolish ambitions," only for the training to deepen them instead. Eventually, he ran away.

"I tried to become a hero immediately," Baoyu continued. "It went... poorly."

Heka snorted.

"I was rescued by Master GNSyiliuba after attempting to fight bandits far beyond my ability," he said. "She set me straight... Then told me I was an idiot." Smiling fondly at the memory, "She agreed to train me only if I could land three clean strikes against her... I got two."

Heka nudged him lightly. "She saw something in you."

"And took me on anyways," Baoyu smiled fondly at Heka. "A decision that has blessed me in many ways..."

The trio were celebrating down in the inn's small restaurant, wine cups never empty and snacks mostly forgotten when the inn's front door suddenly swung open.

"Heka!" A familiar voice rang through the room and drew the attention of the room.

Heka turned instantly. "DFBB!"



A young man stood in the doorway, travel-worn and slightly exasperated, rain dripping from his sleeves. Balanced carefully on his shoulders were two very large, unimpressed cats.

The moment they saw Heka, both cats leapt.

"H-Hey—!" Heka barely had time to react before they landed on her, one on each shoulder, immediately beginning to purr loudly as if they had never been apart. "My babies!" she exclaimed, burying her face in their fur.

DFBB exhaled in relief as Heka finally looked up at him from where she sat on the floor, thoroughly occupied by her two very large cats.

"It's about time you caught up with us," Heka teased. "Master's tests usually don't take so long."

DFBB gave her a tired look but said nothing, apparently deciding that arguing with her was not worth the effort.

Wei watched the exchange with curiosity. She had heard Heka mention DFBB before. Her junior brother. Her fiancé. The marriage arranged by their master.

Seeing him in person was different.

For the first time since deciding to stay, Wei found herself wondering exactly where she fit into this already rather unconventional arrangement. Heka seemed to have an extraordinary ability to collect people and somehow make them all part of the same strange little family.

The thoughts and doubts had no time to settle before Heka was already reaching for her.

"Come on, Wei." She tugged her forward with the same easy confidence she seemed to have about everything else.

"DFBB, this is Weiyun, whom I wrote to you about." A faint blush crossed Heka's cheeks, betraying just how much she had apparently already said about Wei to the people closest to her. "Wei, this is DFBB."

Both bowed their heads respectfully.

"It's nice to finally meet you," Wei said.

"Likewise," DFBB replied.

And then they both paused. Neither seemed entirely certain what came next.

Wei glanced at Heka. Heka glanced between the two of them. Baoyu had wisely chosen to remain silent.

It was a rather unusual situation.

Wei was fairly certain there were no established rules for meeting the fiancé of the already married woman that had been flirting with her shamelessly since the moment they met. .

Heka, apparently unconcerned by any of this, simply smiled brightly at both of them. "Well," she said, "this is going to be fun."

Baoyu finally laughed.

Wei couldn't help smiling as well.

Perhaps it would be a lot of fun, indeed.